FROM LEGACY TO LEADERSHIP: SHAPING THE FUTURE OF ENGINEERING EDUCATION

How Tejshree Abhay Meganathan is leading Rajalakshmi Engineering College into a new era of education, innovation and possibility



"Leadership is about honouring what has been built, while having the courage to reimagine what comes next."

For Tejshree Abhay Meganathan, leadership is deeply personal. As the second generation of the Rajalakshmi Group of Institutions, she has inherited a strong foundation-but her ambition is not simply to carry forward what has been built. It is to expand it, multiply it and take it into its next era.

As Executive Director of the Rajalakshmi Group of Institutions, Tejshree brings together her experience in branding, marketing, strategic communication and education to look at the institution through a distinctly contemporary lens. Her focus is on building an organisation that is not only academically strong, but digitally relevant, innovation-led, future-facing and deeply connected to the aspirations of its students.

At the heart of that journey is Rajalakshmi Engineering College (REC), established in 1997, institution with NAAC A++, NBA and DSIR-SIRO recognition. With more than 18,000 students and over 560 faculty members, REC has grown into a large and dynamic ecosystem of engineering education, research, innovation, entrepreneurship and student life.

But for Tejshree, institutional growth is about far more than numbers.

"An engineering college cannot afford to stand still. Technology changes, industries change, and the aspirations of young people change even faster. Our responsibility is to stay ahead of that curve."

That philosophy has translated into a continuous focus on emerging technologies, artificial intelligence, research, industry collaboration and innovation. REC has built a significant research and innovation ecosystem, with 323 patents filed, 36 patents granted, more than ₹55 crore in research funding and over 250 industrial consultancy projects. Its growing startup culture has also nurtured DPIIT-recognised ventures and hundreds of student innovations.

For Tejshree, however, the transformation of an engineering college is not only about laboratories, patents and research papers. It is also about creating a campus community that students want to be part of. Over the years, she has placed increasing emphasis on the student experience-from strengthening Rajalakshmi's digital presence and creating new ways for students to engage with the institution, to supporting large-scale technical, cultural and sporting events and platforms that allow students to discover and express themselves beyond academics.

The objective is simple: to create a college where students do not merely attend classes, but build friendships, find their communities, experiment with ideas, celebrate their talents and create memories that become an important part of who they are.

Her background in branding and communication has played a significant role in this evolution. Tejshree believes that institutions today need to be experienced as much as they are understood. A great institution must have a strong identity, a vibrant community and a voice that resonates with the generation it serves.

That vision extends beyond the Rajalakshmi campus. Through her work with the Confederation of Indian Industry's Indian Women Network, Tejshree has championed entrepreneurship, mentorship and leadership opportunities for women, reflecting her belief that meaningful leadership is ultimately about creating opportunities for others to grow.

Yet perhaps the most defining part of Tejshree's leadership journey exists outside the boardroom. She is building this next chapter while raising three young children, navigating the demands of motherhood alongside the responsibilities of leading and growing a large institution. It is a balancing act that requires constant prioritisation, resilience and, above all, a strong support system.

Tejshree is the first to acknowledge that the pace and scale at which she is able to pursue her ambitions would not be possible without the people around her.

"I am fortunate to have a husband and a family who understand what I am trying to build and support me through it. You can dream big, but having people who believe in that dream with you makes all the difference."

For her, that support has made it possible to embrace both sides of her life wholeheartedly—to be present for her children while continuing to build, lead and dream ambitiously for the institution she represents.

Her journey is ultimately about evolution of an institution, of a family legacy and of herself. She is taking an organisation built by the first generation and pushing it towards a future that is more digital, more innovative, more research-driven, more connected to industry and more responsive to the aspirations of a new generation.

The ambition is not simply to preserve a legacy. It is to build on it with courage, create something bigger from it, and ensure that the next generation inherits not just an institution—but a platform filled with possibility.

For Tejshree Abhay Meganathan, that is what leadership looks like: honouring what has been built, while having the courage to reimagine what comes next.